

Net neutrality

Net neutrality is the idea that internet service providers (ISPs) should treat all data online in the same way, and not block, discriminate, or charge users differently to access data.

What is net neutrality?

Net neutrality prevents telecom companies and ISPs from picking and choosing what content people can access. This includes blocking or censoring websites, as well as throttling (intentionally slowing) their service. Opponents of net neutrality claim that not all content is created equal. They feel that certain sites should be restricted, that people should pay more to access websites that are primarily concerned with entertainment, and that people should be able to pick what internet services they want to pay for. Certain governments are already able to restrict access to large parts of the internet.

▽ Two internets

Many people believe that scrapping net neutrality would create a “poor internet” with limited services and a “rich internet” with full access to services. Access to content, resources, and education would depend on what a user can afford.

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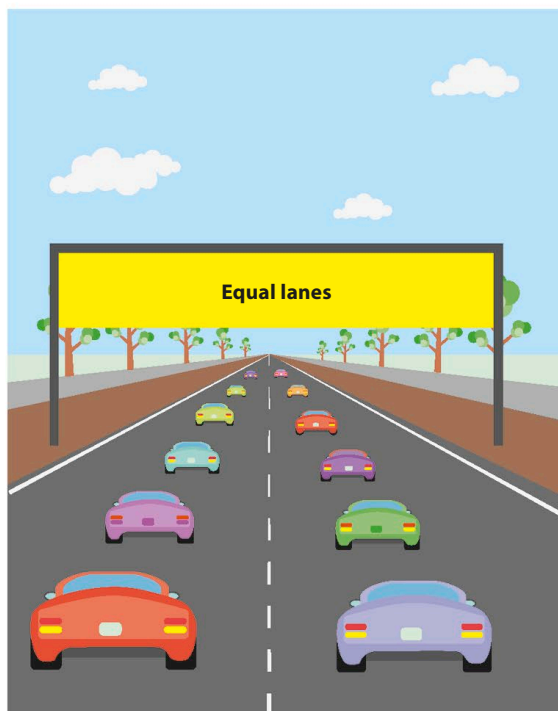
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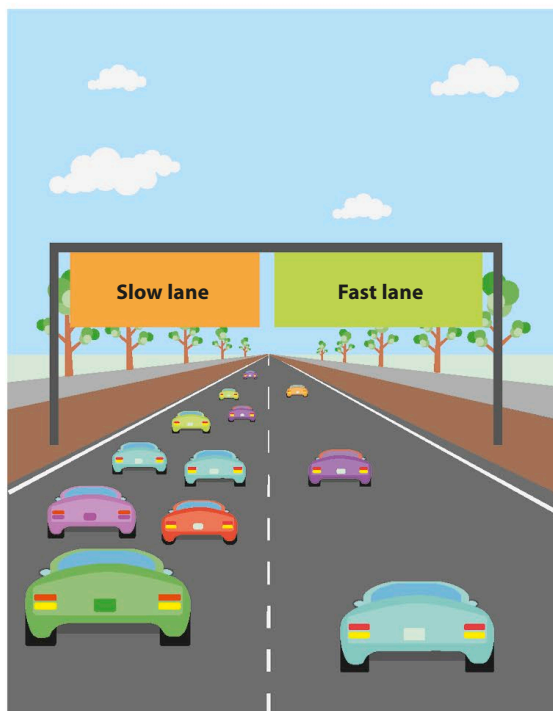
Preventing cybercrime

Many net neutrality laws include privacy protections, such as requiring customer consent before monitoring or sharing personal data. While generally a good thing, this also protects cybercriminals. If ISPs monitored networks they could tell which customers were involved with criminal websites. However, critics argue that preventing crime isn't – and shouldn't be – the job of ISPs.



△ Equal treatment

Since its inception, the internet has been mostly neutral. The majority of users can access the same data in the same way.



△ Preferential treatment

If net neutrality were abandoned, users who could not afford the expensive fast lane would be stuck with a slow or restricted service.